

Michael Hsin-Huang Hsiao, Yu-Yuan Kuan and Shu-Yung Wang (eds.), *Taiwan's Social Welfare Movements and Policy Impact, 2000–2018* [台灣的社會福利運動與政策效應: 2000–2018]. Taipei: Chuliu Publishers, 2018. 496 pages + illus., NT\$650, ISBN: 9789577325709 (pbk).

Taiwan's Social Welfare Movement and Policy Impact, 2000–2018 is a direct sequel to a volume published in 2000 (Hsiao & Lin, 2000). That book, titled *Taiwan's Social Welfare Movement*, dealt with Taiwan's welfare movements during the era of political liberalisation but omitted discussion of policy influence. Building upon the previous publication, the 2018 volume focuses on social welfare movements in democratic Taiwan with a specific emphasis on how movements influence policies and vice versa. Since 2000 the two turnovers of political power have qualified Taiwan as a consolidated democracy. The new volume documents closely how social welfare movements have developed and evolved from 2000 to 2018. Each chapter documents the fight on a social issue, mostly from the activists' points of view.

The central inquiry *Taiwan's Social Welfare Movement and Policy Impact* explores is how democratic transition and the actual practice of democracy shape (or reshape) the contours of social welfare movements. Under this overarching theme, the volume sets out to answer three specific questions. First, does democracy lead to a more moderate bargaining approach within political institutions and shift welfare movements away from the traditional, more aggressive, grassroots approach? Second, in the digital era, how have social media influenced movements and mobilisation strategies? Finally, have democracy and technological innovation transformed the leadership and structure of movements during the past 20 years? (p. 15).

The findings emerging out of the edited volume are as follows: first, on movement strategies, grassroots protests and mobilisation remain important tools under democracy. That being said, direct bargaining within the political institution and participation in the policymaking process have become another common advocacy strategy coexisting with the traditional street approach. Second, Taiwan has also experienced more diverse and more creative movement strategies in the past 20 years. For example, litigation has become an effective tool for the environmental movement and the recent fight for marriage equality. New advocacy discourses and media also emerge in the digital era. Third, social movements have become more professionalised and institutionalised, with more full-time activists now than previously. With the growing complexity of social issues, collaborations between activists and experts in various fields are also common to pursue evidence-based activism. While inter-organisational collaborations are prevalent, conflicts between

organisations remain, and such conflicts are usually consequences of different activist groups' sometimes conflicting mobilisation strategies and movement goals. The new challenge for civil society moving forward is how to coordinate and collaborate between activist groups (pp. 16–23).

To fully appreciate the contribution of the 2018 volume, it is worth comparing it and the 2000 volume side by side. A close comparison shows the 2018 volume's contributions in four different aspects. First, the 2018 volume covers a wider range of topics, such as marriage equality (Chap. 6), the caregivers' movement (Chaps. 9 and 10), non-standard workers' rights (Chap. 12), and youth civic engagement movements (Chap. 16), and so on. Its ambitious coverage advances our understanding of Taiwan's welfare state system on various fronts. In comparison, the previous edited book encompasses more traditional social policy issues, such as health insurance, pension, labour unions, and gender equality. In some sense, the expansion of issue coverage reflects the 'democratisation' of social welfare movements. Under the democratic political culture, Taiwan's civil society has grown, expanding both in depth and breadth over the past 20 years, providing a fertile ground for politics of differences and a more inclusive civil society. More diverse social groups seek to be identified, recognised, and protected, even including physicians who were once viewed by society as a privileged group (Chap. 14). Democratic institutions and the policymaking process can also accommodate and mediate more conflicts, leaving room for the various social groups to influence and shape social policies.

Second, 'democratisation' is reflected not only in the topics covered but also in the backgrounds of the authors. While most of the contributors in the previous volume were from academia, the new volume includes contributors from more diverse backgrounds. Many of them are full-time NGO workers and activists writing from the perspective of civil society, making the 2018 volume truly an 'activist-centred' book. In this sense, even the knowledge production process has been 'democratised'. I suspect a more balanced authorship between academia and civil society was a deliberate choice and the publication itself is another method of advocacy.

Third, the 2018 volume covers not only a longer period of time but also three different administrations under democracy (Chen Shui-bian, Ma Ying-jeou, and Tsai Ing-wen). The 2000 volume covers mostly the years of political liberalisation prior to democratisation. Against the authoritarian regime at the time, activists and social movements had worked closely as allies with the Tang-Wai (*dangwai*, literally 'outside the party') democratic movement, which later became the Democratic Progressive Party (DPP).

The longer timespan covered in the 2018 volume allows for more variations. Tracing the same welfare movement across different administrations help reveals that the DPP administration is not always civil society's ally. The anti-nuclear movement is a great example (Chap. 19). Sometimes, the DPP administration is as pro-capitalist as the Kuomintang administration. The 2018 volume shows the process by which civil society tried to develop and negotiate new relationships with different political parties after democratisation. It also shows that on many social issues, civil society fought against the state itself, not the government administrations.

Finally, there is some continuity and clear progress between the two books. For instance, the fight on gender equality has gone beyond the levelling up women's rights and protection that was featured in the 2000 volume. In the past ten years, politics has revolved around protection for sexual minorities and marriage equality, and such progress is documented in the 2018 volume (in Chaps. 5 and 6). In the same vein, similar continuation and progression can be spotted in the doctor–patient relationship. In the 2000 volume, the fight centred on advocating patients' rights and a more equal doctor–patient relationship. In the 2018 volume, social welfare movements still exist in hospitals, but now the focus has shifted to physicians fighting for their rights (Chap. 14).

A useful framework for the welfare state politics, developed by Ian Gough (2008), distinguishes five different dimensions shaping social policy development: structure (industrialisation), interest, political institutions, ideas, and international influence. The ultimate contribution this book makes is to enhance our understanding on the *interest* factor of the five dimensions in Taiwan's context. While the book does an excellent job in detailing activists' interests and mobilisation over social issues, it does not show the same level of analysis and consistency across chapters documenting how interest interacts with political institutions or how interests are (re)shaped by structural changes over time. Despite its small shortcomings, *Taiwan's Social Welfare Movement and Policy Impact, 2000–2018* is still valuable for scholars studying Taiwan's welfare state and policymakers working on these social issues.

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